

Vuka — Master Plan: Identity, Pricing & Roadmap

Working document. Built from the Zishapp competitive analysis, the fee/plan conversation, and the pre-launch build list. Treat the numbers here as the locked starting model — tune them once real unit economics (payment processor costs, actual payout volume) come in.

1. What Vuka is

Vuka is a **direct-to-fan music commerce and creator-economy platform** — not a distributor. Concretely, that means: artists sell tracks, EPs, and beats directly to fans; run a paid fan club with membership tiers and exclusive content; have a personal storefront; and, once built, run crowdfunding campaigns and sell event tickets. There is no DSP delivery to Spotify/Apple Music today, and nothing in messaging, pricing, or sales conversations should imply otherwise until that's real.

This is the pitch for everyone, including artists who already have a distributor: **Vuka is the layer you add, not the one you switch**. A label or established artist keeps whatever gets their music onto Spotify and Apple Music today — DistroKid, a label deal, an aggregator — and adds Vuka as where their real fans buy direct, where the fan club lives, where exclusive content and crowdfunding happen. That's a much smaller ask than "move your distribution," and it's the only honest pitch given what's actually built.

If real DSP distribution gets built later, it becomes an expansion of this platform, not a repositioning of it. Don't pre-sell it. Full timeline and economics for when that becomes worth pursuing are in §7 — it's a revenue-and-demand decision, not a fixed multi-year wait.

2. Plans & fees — the auto-stepping model

Free — R0/month, no card required.

Lifetime gross sales on Vuka	Platform fee
R0 - R2,000	10%
R2,000 - R10,000	9%
R10,000+	8.5% (permanent floor on Free)

The fee improves automatically as an artist sells more — no subscription, no opt-in, nothing to negotiate. It starts at the same rate as Zishapp's flat 10%, so there's never a "you're worse than them" objection on an artist's very first sale, and it only gets better from there. This needs a `lifetimeGrossSales` running total on the Artist model and an extended version of the `platformFeeRate()` helper referenced in the build list — build that

in the same pass as the admin finance hardcoded-8%-fee bug fix, since both touch the same fee-lookup logic.

Pro — R249/month. Flat 8% fee, unlimited releases (vs. a cap on Free), full creator-economy unlock once those features ship (memberships, exclusive content, crowdfunding, events), faster payout SLA, a visible trust badge on the public profile. Sold on capability, not fee relief — the fee gap over Free's floor is intentionally small (8% vs. 8.5%) because the real reason to upgrade is everything else on this list.

Label — R999/month. Flat 5% fee. This tier only earns its price if it comes with something Free/Pro genuinely can't do — see the open gap flagged in §6. Until that's built, position Label as a negotiable, white-glove tier for high-volume or "big" artists rather than a rigid self-serve SKU: custom terms, direct onboarding, priority support.

Standing commitments across every tier — this is the actual anti-Zishapp stance, not just a pricing table:

- One fee, full stop. No separate surcharge for crowdfunding, no separate fee for events, ever.
- Discovery never expires. No "pay an annual fee or your catalogue disappears." A release stays visible and findable for as long as the artist's account exists.
- Non-exclusive. Artists keep whatever distributor relationship they already have.
- The fee improves with growth automatically — it's a reward mechanic, not a tax that only goes away if you pay a subscription.

3. What each plan includes

	Free	Pro (R249/mo)	Label (R999/mo)
Platform fee	10% → 8.5% (auto-stepping)	8% flat	5% flat
Releases per month	Capped	Unlimited	Unlimited
Storefront	Basic	Full customization	Full customization
Fan memberships / exclusive content	—	Yes (once built)	Yes (once built)
Crowdfunding campaigns	—	Yes (once built)	Yes (once built)
Event ticketing	—	Yes (once built)	Yes (once built)
Payout speed	Standard	Priority	Priority
Profile trust badge	—	Pro badge	Label badge

	Free	Pro (R249/mo)	Label (R999/mo)
Support	Self-serve	Standard	White-glove / negotiable
Roster / multi-artist management	—	—	Yes — full spec in §4a
Automated label-artist royalty splits	—	—	Yes — see §4a
Public label page (aggregates roster)	—	—	Yes — see §4a

4. The four features being added, reimagined rather than copied

Priority order, with the specific mechanic that beats Zishapp's version of each:

1. **Crowdfunding.** Extend the existing `Goal` model into full campaigns with backer tiers, rewards, and all-or-nothing refund logic. No separate fee — it runs on the same tiered platform fee as everything else, unlike Zishapp's extra 10% crowdfunding cut.
2. **Plaques / milestones.** Multi-dimensional (sales, streams, fan-membership revenue, followers — not sales-units only), with a much lower entry tier than Zishapp's 100-sale Bronze threshold so new artists get an early win. Each plaque auto-generates a shareable graphic for social, turning gamification into free marketing.
3. **Events.** Bundled with the existing follow/notification system and the merch/membership checkout, so a ticket purchase can include merch and exclusive content in one flow — something Zishapp can't do without the membership layer it doesn't have.
4. **Awards & fan voting.** Weighted partly by real platform analytics (sales/streams already tracked), not pure popularity votes, to reduce vote-buying and brigading.

Plus the artist/fan referral loop tied to memberships (a fan who brings in a paying member earns a credit or perk), which folds naturally into the Founding Artist Programme below.

4a. Label tier — full specification

The decision from §6 is resolved: Label gets built out, not renamed. This is the tier meant to make a real label feel they'd be foolish not to use Vuka. Checked against the schema — `RevenueRecord`, `Invoice`, and `TaxRecord` already track everything per artist, so most of this is an aggregation problem once the roster-linking layer exists, not a rebuild from scratch.

Roster & team core (build first — this is what unlocks a label saying yes at all). A `Label` entity with a join table linking it to artist accounts. Artists are invited and must accept — they keep ownership of their own account and can leave the roster, so this never becomes

a label silently controlling someone's earnings. Multiple team seats with permission tiers: label admin (full access), manager/A&R (limited edit), accountant (financial view only). One consolidated dashboard showing aggregate stats across the whole roster, with drill-down into any individual artist's existing analytics.

Automated label-artist royalty splits (build second — this is the feature that makes them stay, not just sign up). The label sets each artist's contractual revenue share inside Vuka; every sale auto-splits and pays both sides at the point of transaction, with no manual calculation or out-of-pocket payments required from the label. Paired with recoupment tracking for advances or recording costs the label fronted, so the label can see exactly what's been recouped against each artist in real time. Nothing in Zishapp's screenshots resembles this, and it's the single strongest reason a real label would choose Vuka over running royalties in a spreadsheet.

Operations at scale (build third). Bulk release scheduling and metadata edits across the whole catalogue. A shared release calendar so two roster artists don't drop in the same week by accident. One-click consolidated financial statements across the roster for accounting and tax, built directly on the existing per-artist revenue/tax data.

Prestige & marketing (build fourth). A public label page aggregating every roster artist under the label's own brand — something Zishapp has no equivalent of. Priority discovery placement for roster artists as a tangible, visible perk of the tier.

Service level (formalize last, once there's a team to deliver it). A dedicated account contact instead of a support ticket queue, negotiable rates below the standard 5% for genuinely high-volume labels, expedited payouts, and early access to new features before general release.

5. Build list — organized into this plan

Pulled from the pre-launch audit, grouped by urgency.

Critical — fix before any artist signs up:

- Fix the "Payouts every Friday" copy in `dashboard/earnings/page.tsx` — no such schedule exists in code; replace with accurate processing-time language.
- Replace "Faithworth" with the real (or placeholder pending-registration) company name in Terms of Service.
- Wire the "Request Withdrawal" button in `dashboard/payouts/page.tsx` — the API already works, it just isn't connected to a button.
- Fix the memberships form bug sending `price` instead of `priceMonthly`.
- Verify Resend DNS for `mail.vuka.co.za` so transactional emails stop landing in spam.
- Hide the Ozow/Yoco "Coming soon" cards from artists (admin-only, or remove).

Founding Artist Programme — to build:

- Referral link system (`(?ref=)` param, `referredBy` field on User, a referrals API endpoint).
- Auto-grant: extend Pro plan by 3 months when an artist hits 5 referrals (the admin plan-grant API already supports this — needs a trigger).
- Permanent "Founding Artist" badge on profile (`isFoundingArtist` flag on Artist).
- A referrals tab in the artist dashboard showing link, signup count, and reward status.
- Worth deciding now: reserve some of the first 5 founding slots for artists with real existing followings rather than first-come-first-served, since the social proof value is much higher from a known name.

Pre-launch admin setup — no code, just needs doing:

- Grant Pro plan to the 5 Founding Artists manually once they sign up.
- Run one real end-to-end test transaction (Paystack test card) and screenshot every step — that screenshot becomes the proof you show artists on launch day.
- Create the Paystack Pro/Label plan products and webhook registration.

Security — fix before real money is flowing at volume:

- Implement PayPal webhook signature verification (currently stubbed, spoofable).
- Wire AES-256-GCM encryption to `ArtistBankAccount.accountNumber` (the helper already exists, just isn't connected).
- Fix the admin finance page's hardcoded 8% fee — do this alongside the auto-stepping fee build in §2, since it's the same underlying fee-lookup function.

Growth infrastructure — months 2-3:

- Onboarding checklist / nudge sequence for new artists who sign up and never upload.
- **Artist Agreement one-pager** — pull this forward ahead of approaching any "big" artist specifically; it's the trust document that makes a previously-burned SA artist comfortable signing, and it matters more for landing bigger names than any fee number does.
- Media kit / shareable one-pager for word-of-mouth.
- Install Sentry for error tracking.

When revenue allows:

- RISA registrant code and GS1 company prefix, replacing the placeholder ISRC/UPC codes — required before any of this can be called commercial-grade distribution, whenever that becomes the goal.

6. Open decisions and gaps to resolve

- **Label tier roster gap — resolved.** Full specification now lives in §4a: roster/team management, automated label-artist royalty splits, and a public label page, sequenced in build order. The underlying financial data already exists per-artist; what's missing is the roster-linking layer itself.
- **Distribution timeline — resolved.** Full readiness gate, aggregator economics, and artist-facing pricing now in §7. It's a conditional decision (revenue + demand + stability), not a fixed wait.
- **Auto-step thresholds.** R2,000 / R10,000 / 8.5% floor are a reasonable starting model based on the screenshots' price points (R15–R60 per release), not a calculation against your actual payment-processor costs. Revisit once there's real transaction volume to check the margin holds at the 10% starting rate.

7. Real DSP distribution — timeline and economics

Pricing for this checked against published 2026 rates from Revelator, SonoSuite, and LabelGrid (mid-market USD/ZAR ≈ R16.3, June 2026). Treat the figures below as a planning model, not a quote — confirm directly with whichever vendor gets shortlisted.

Readiness gate — pursue this only once all three are true:

1. Pro and Label subscriptions together generate at least R40,000/month in recurring revenue, sustained for three consecutive months. That's roughly 150–160 paying Pro/Label artists, and it's the point where a R2,000–R4,100/month aggregator subscription is a rounding error rather than a bet on uncertain uptake.
2. At least 50 artists have explicitly said they want real DSP distribution — a waitlist or direct survey, not assumed demand. Subscription growth could come entirely from the creator-economy features in §4 and §4a; that doesn't prove distribution demand on its own.
3. The critical pre-launch fixes and security gaps in §5 are fully resolved and stable. Layering a new high-stakes integration on top of an unstable payout foundation multiplies risk rather than just adding a feature.

Choosing the aggregator — the underlying principle matters more than the brand name. Revelator's flat \$249/month includes a 100% default payout rate, meaning no revenue share is taken before Vuka applies its own fee — Vuka pays a fixed cost and keeps full, transparent control of the markup. By contrast, LabelGrid's cheapest tiers (\$99–499/year) only retain 85–90% of royalties at the low end, so a slice disappears upstream before Vuka's own fee is even applied — that undercuts the "one fee, full stop" principle from §2. SonoSuite doesn't publish pricing or retention rates publicly; get both figures in writing during vendor evaluation and check them against the 100%-retention principle before signing, rather than treating "maybe SonoSuite" as settled. A realistic entry-level budget for an API-integrable plan from a comparable provider is roughly R23,000–R49,000/year (~R2,000–R4,100/month).

What to charge artists once it's live, keeping the existing no-surcharge ethos intact:

Plan	Real distribution
Free	Not included by default. Available as a one-off ~R150-250 fee per release sent to DSPs — the same "pay once per release" model artists already expect from TuneCore.
Pro (R249/mo)	Included, unlimited releases, no extra fee. This becomes the headline reason to upgrade from Free, alongside the existing creator-economy unlock.
Label (R999/mo)	Included, plus bulk roster-wide distribution once the §4a roster layer is built.

No per-release surcharge for paying tiers, no ongoing revenue-share creep beyond the chosen aggregator's own cut (which should be at or near 0% if the 100%-retention principle above is followed) — Free artists pay small and once rather than being locked out of real distribution entirely.